In terms of space, each student gets 2 MB of e-mail and 100 MB for personal use. This is further supplemented by space allotted for different activities and clubs.

For the system administrator, too, it was very different after the upgrade. There was now the ability to create storage facilities according to requirements. A staff member could have separate drives for personal and department use. Access rights could then be managed; for example, a department head could access and manage the entire "department data" drive. Similarly, each class could have a drive with read-write privileges for the teacher and read-only for the students; this would be where the students handed in assignments. Configuration possibilities became as varied as the requirements of different teams.

Multiple servers meant that now, when the e-mail server needed maintenance, for example, there was no reason for applications such as the ERP or accounting suites to stop functioning.

Data backup was another area where having a SAN really helped. "Trying to take backups of our information from 18 servers and 300 desktops was such a nightmare that we chose to only back up our mission-critical infrastructure on a monthly basis. Our exposure was high, and our information was at risk," says Ediger. "Today our information is not just safe; it is more effectively shared, protected, backed up and leveraged. It takes a huge load off of my servers, and I am able to use them and utilise them far more effectively than before. Backing our data up is just so easy now—I can see at least a twenty-fold improvement!"

The process is fully automated to boot. Once scheduled, using a Veritas storage solution software, the administrator can literally take a walk or a nap. The 20 robotic slot tape changers automatically replace tapes. The EMC/Dell CLARiiON CX 300 system is a RAID 5 setup, which in this case means there are nine drives on a storage server.

The Use Of The Internet

Asked about students accessing the Internet and whether any monitoring or censorship is exercised, Ediger reasons, "Apart from the prohibitive cost of filtering software, we realise they often don't keep people out from where they shouldn't be. So the students' access is restricted to the Internet centre in the presence of supervisors."

In any case, at Woodstock, the Internet is not the primary source of information for the students. They have the 37,000 volumes in the library and the 80-odd reference CDs and DVDs to exhaust first! This, according to Ediger, is primarily to develop a "right learning strategy," while keeping in mind the costs of bandwidth.

Why So Much Tech?

Coming to learning strategies, one might ask, what is the need for so much tech in a school? Why is there such prolific use of computers, right from the kindergarten level? What exactly is the philosophy behind the IT investment?

"Computers are nothing more than the slate and chalk of today," is how Principal Jeffery understates what he calls "the contemporary learning tool." He adds, "Education is not about filling an empty receptacle—the learner—with information, but equipping him to think for himself. To this end, the use of computers offers many opportunities."

Besides that, Jeffery goes on to say, "We are an international community drawn from 35 countries around the world. And communication is essential for students and staff alike. A robust infrastructure serves this critical purpose. "

IT is being harnessed to its optimum at Woodstock, acting as an enabler to "opening up the mind."

To this end, an assessment to optimise the use of technology in education is being carried out. Some of the issues of immediate concern being discussed include revisiting the proposal of providing students and teachers with laptops, which is currently on hold, coupled with that of setting up a Wi-Fi network that would cover all of the 300 acres.

At The End Of The Day...

It's remarkable how an institution more than a hundred years old has kept pace and transformed itself into something of a precedent-setting school for the 21st century. Of course, not everyone can afford the kind of infrastructure here, but any modern school would do well to take a cue from Woodstock's wired philosophy. ⊠

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Blackbaud

Blackbaud is an ERP suite. It comprises several modules designed for not-for-profit organisations. Those implemented at Woodstock are Education Edge, Financial Edge and Raiser's Edge.

Raiser's Edge helps organisations of all types and sizes to raise money. This solution supports traditional and diversified fundraising methods, automates administrative processes, and provides insightful reports.

Financial Edge provides the power to develop budgets, control spending and achieve accountability.

Blackbaud's total school solution, including Education Edge, provides all who need to know—including parents, teachers and supervisors—with instant, secure access to up-to-date student and financial information. The solution also allows schools to extend their communication efforts to the Web, keeping parents, students and alumni in the loop at all times.

A typical application of Education Edge is in scheduling exams. In a school such as Woodstock, which offers 50 electives to a high school student, ensuring that every student need not take more than two papers a day within the stipulated exam date becomes an involved permutation and combination problem, which is effectively solved by the software. Providing parents with real-time access to student records is another complex archiving activity handled by the suite.

The young take to IT at Woodstock